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‘Doubles becomes important because it will come up somewhere in the first three matches of a team event. I won’t call it a safety net, but a good doubles pair is a confidence booster’



coming through the ranks in badminton, everyone is tempted to ask questions like — who the next Sindhu is, who the next Saina is, who will headline the future for Indian badminton?

When the results came, I thought it was a fitting reply and I hope this question doesn’t come up at least for a few days. We’ve been saying there

are many talented players out there, but they were just visible in flashes. I don’t know if it’s a good problem that we have maybe five or seven girls who are talented, but then we weren’t able to identify those one or two who were really outshining the others over a period of time.

That is what I want to see now. I want to see players maintain their

form; and this doesn’t involve only performance because that is sometimes dictated by the draw. These players should maintain a certain standard of play without being erratic. The second thing we need to track is the improvement curve. An upward trajectory is important but also as we have seen with Saina and Sindhu, the speed of improvement is of essence. Ideally, we need good players with a steeper upward curve.

Gopi Chand, in an interview recently, said that Anmol and Ashmita might now be marked. My interpretation of this is that there is scope to learn and fix. I don’t say fix because something is broken, but because that kind of learning has to happen constantly to perform at a high level.

Looking ahead to the Paris Games

I am expecting two medals, and maybe even three for India at the Paris Games. Three will be outstanding.

This last leg ahead of Paris will be spent focusing on securing qualification for a few and peaking at the right time for others. Workload management will be an important consideration here.

Prannoy and Satwik/Chirag might have a choice to skip a tournament or two if they want, but the same may not be true for Sindhu or our womens doubles pairs who want those ranking points and competition exposure.

One important thing that we as the ecosystem should remember is to not read too much into the performances over the next few months.

From now until the Olympics, players will strategically prepare to ready themselves for the Games. It’s the process not the result, so hopefully critics, fans and the media are kind to the players through it all.

The author is a two-time Olympian, Commonwealth Games silver medallist, and nine-time Senior National badminton champion